

Ammonites

Ammonite fossils are unmistakable, thanks to their beautiful coiled shapes. These sea creatures were close relatives of today's octopuses and squids but lived inside a shell, which they enlarged with new chambers as they grew, forming a spiral. They lived throughout the seas and swam by squirting water, the hollow inner chambers of their shells acting as air tanks to help them float.



FAMILY FACT FILE

Key features

- Coiled shell divided into chambers
- Soft body inside the outermost chamber
- Large head and well-developed eyes
- Long tentacles for capturing prey

When

Ammonites appeared 425 million years ago and were very common in the oceans throughout the age of the dinosaurs. They perished at the same time as the dinosaurs, 65 million years ago.



Scaphites fossil

The shell's outermost chamber housed the ammonite's soft body.

Scaphites

scaff-EYE-tees

- **When** 144–65 million years ago (Late Cretaceous)
- **Fossil location** Europe, Africa, India, N. America, S. America
- **Habitat** Shallow seas
- **Size** Up to 8 in (20 cm) across

Scaphites was an unusual ammonite. Instead of forming a neat spiral, its shell grew in a crooked shape. As a result, the opening for its head would have gotten tighter and tighter as *Scaphites* grew, eventually starving the animal to death. Perhaps *Scaphites* only lived long enough to lay its eggs, dying soon after, as happens in octopuses.

Promicroceras

pro-my-CROSS-e-ras

- **When** 200 million years ago (Early Jurassic)
- **Fossil location** Worldwide
- **Habitat** Seas
- **Size** Up to ¾ in (2 cm) across

Vast numbers of *Promicroceras* died at the same time, carpeting the seafloor with shells. Over time, these turned into fossils, forming an amazing type of rock called Marston marble, which consists of almost nothing but ammonites. The cause of the mass death is a mystery, but one possibility is poisoning of seawater by algae (microscopic plants).

Marston marble

Echioceras

ECK-ee-oh-se-ras

- **When** 200 million years ago (Early Jurassic)
- **Fossil location** Worldwide
- **Habitat** Seas
- **Size** Up to 2½ in (6 cm) across

Echioceras had a tightly coiled shell, which may have made it difficult to move rapidly. It preyed on other slow-moving creatures in the Jurassic seas.



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